‘aware of its inadequacies’ is ‘without the intellectual means to move ahead’.[2] Naipaul’s broad-stroke analysis, when applied to Indian foreign policy, would suggest a desire for international respect without having the resources to exercise global power and a refusal to accept that reality.

Another perspective is offered by Sunil Khilnani, who, in *The Idea of India* (1997), argues that contemporary India has been shaped by a ‘wager’ of India’s educated urban elite on modern ideas and modern agencies. ‘It was a wager on an idea: the idea of India,’ Khilnani argues. India’s ‘nationalist elite itself had no single, clear definition of this idea and one of the remarkable facts about the nationalist movement that brought India to independence was its capacity to entertain diverse, often contending visions of India … Indian nationalism before independence was plural even at the top, a dhoti with endless folds. … It contains people from markedly different backgrounds yet whose trajectories were often parallel.’[3] According to this standpoint, nationalism subsumed India’s diversity and its advocates hoped to build a modern India inspired by the past but connected to the present and looking towards the future.

In *Emerging Power: India* (2001) Stephen Cohen classifies Indian strategic thought as divided between those he styles Nehruvian (which includes the Gandhian view), militant Nehruvian and finally Realists and Revivalists.[4] Similarly, in his book *India’s Foreign Policy: Retrospect and Prospect* (2010) political scientist Sumit Ganguly argues that personal, national and systemic factors framed Nehru’s views and were responsible every time any of Nehru’s successors changed or adapted his policies.[5] This view casts Nehru and his ideas as the major point of reference in modern India’s world view.

Indians take pride in the fact that India is a 5000-year-old civilization even if its modern incarnation as a democratic state is only seventy years old. Modern India’s founding fathers, Nehru being the most significant among them, sought to craft policies that would incorporate both India’s